waiting point further and further away by a few kilometres, simply because the queue of people walking with Rahul wasn't ending.

As the sun slowly began setting, I began to give up. In my mind, I was already making plans to return the next day and walk way behind in the Yatra, as was my original plan. But Vikram suddenly grabbed my hand and pulled me towards the approaching surge. Honestly, having never even been part of a rally (let alone such a yatra), I was petrified. There were cops everywhere, but they were outnumbered by the onlookers. There was sloganeering and cheering and flag-waving. And among all of them was Rahul Gandhi walking with a determined smile on his face.

As I got through the ropes into the first layer of security, I was frisked while walking and was given a thumbs-up to proceed to the second layer. I was running to catch up with Rahul, who had marched ahead by then even as another security guard decided to check my legs for any hidden weapons. I almost tripped and fell due to nervousness. But then the stars aligned and suddenly I was right beside Rahul, just like that, not more than a foot apart. Rahul smiled warmly and said, 'Hello.' My mouth went dry, but I gathered myself and quickly introduced myself to him. We exchanged brief pleasantries before the real conversation began.

Rahul: So what made you decide to join the Bharat Jodo Yatra?

Me: Your walk is giving us a lot of hope. It is inspiring. But what do you have to say to society, about the fear that is being generated?

Rahul: The fear is not in the society—the fear is inside you. Tell me, aren't you scared, coming here, walking with me?

Me: Of course I am!

Rahul: And yet you are here. Because you have conquered the fear inside you. That's what everyone has to do. If you are not afraid, they can't scare you. *[At this juncture, Rahul affectionately put his arm around my shoulder, as if to give me courage.]*